

transboundary viral disease of cloven-footed animals and is endemic in India, causing major economic losses due to reduced productivity and trade restrictions. Under the Livestock Health & Disease Control Programme (LHDCP), India aims to control and eliminate FMD by 2030 through systematic vaccination. For this, quality-tested trivalent FMDvaccines are centrally procured and supplied to States/UTs. The programme implements biannual vaccination for all eligible cattle and buffaloes (and sheep/goats in select pastoral States), with a booster dose for first-time vaccinated calves after 30–45 days. The interval between vaccination rounds is maintained at less than six months. Since 2020, over 125 crore FMD vaccinations have been administered. States receive 100% central financial assistance for vaccination, logistics, cold-chain infrastructure, vaccinators, ear-tagging, data entry on the Bharat Pashudhan Portal, and awareness activities. State Animal Husbandry Departments are responsible for on-field implementation and micro-planning. All vaccinated animals are uniquely ear-tagged and vaccination records are digitally captured.

PROMOTING ENTREPRENEURSHIP – INFUSING YOUNG BLOOD & EMPLOYMENT GENERATION

India's livestock economy includes goats, sheep, pigs, poultry, and feed/fodder enterprises. The National Livestock Mission (NLM) encourages entrepreneurship and job creation, integrating women Self-Help Groups into Livestock entrepreneurship, creating more rural employment. The Central Government through its schemes offers 50% capital subsidy for setting up parent layer farms and sheep or goat breeding farms and piggery, promoting rural poultry and livestock development.

ANIMAL HUSBANDRY INFRASTRUCTURE FUND-POWERING PRIVATE SECTOR INVESTMENT

The Rs 29,000 crore outlay AHIDF has been approved for incentivizing investments by individual entrepreneurs, private companies, MSME, Farmers Producers Organizations (FPOs) and Section 8 companies to establish (i) the dairy processing and value addition infrastructure, (ii) meat processing and value addition infrastructure and (iii) Animal Feed Plant. Keeping in view of the success of AHIDF, the erstwhile Dairy Processing Infrastructure Development Fund has been subsumed with the AHIDF on 01.02.2024. Now total size of the fund is Rs 29110 crore. Till date ₹24500 crore investment has been leveraged in 523 approved projects. AHIDF ensures broad sectoral coverage by supporting activities such as dairy and meat processing, animal feed manufacturing, breed improvement and multiplication farms, veterinary vaccine and drug production, animal waste-to-wealth initiatives, and primary wool processing infrastructure. Over time, these areas have gained significant momentum, attracting projects even from remote districts that previously had minimal participation, underscoring the scheme's extensive outreach and transformative impact on the animal husbandry sector.

LIVESTOCK SECTOR AS A CIRCULATORY POVERTY ALLEVIATION INPUT

The livestock sector acts as a powerful circulatory poverty alleviation mechanism, especially for small and marginal farmers, landless households, women, and youth. Animal Husbandry sector provides livelihood support to more than 10 crore rural households and about 8.5 cr farmers engaged in dairying.

By promoting entrepreneurship, doorstep veterinary and breeding services, value addition, organized procurement, and feed–fodder self-sufficiency, income opportunities are created across the entire value chain—from input supply and animal rearing to processing and marketing. Increased productivity, assured market access, and disease-free livestock lead to stable and recurring incomes, improved nutrition, and enhanced resilience in climate-vulnerable and low-literacy regions. This continuous flow of income, employment, and services generates a multiplier effect, strengthening rural livelihoods and enabling inclusive and sustainable poverty reduction.

WAY FORWARD

Looking ahead to Viksit Bharat @2047, India envisions a technologically advanced, sustainable, and globally competitive livestock sector. By 2047, milk production is targeted to reach 600 million tonne, egg production 588 billion, and meat production 27 million tonnes. Per capita availability of milk is projected to double to 1 kg per person per day, and average productivity of cattle and buffaloes to rise to 5,500 kg per animal per year. Our goal is to make India free from all major livestock diseases by 2047. This will open new markets for our farmers, improve food safety, and strengthen India's position as a global leader. To realize this vision, the focus will be on entrepreneurship development, technology-driven and traceable animal rearing, value addition and processing, and self-sufficiency in feed and fodder. Promoting Entrepreneurship will have a multiplier effect to create wealth ensuring quality services at doorstep of farmers. Supporting start ups in the animal husbandry sector and providing incubation facilities will lead to self-sufficiency as well as provide employment and income to the youth of the country.

CONCLUSION

India's livestock sector has witnessed steady transformation in the last ten years driven by increased production, rising GVA, and improved international trade. Growth in milk, meat, and egg production has enhanced nutritional security and rural employment. The staggering increase in GVA shows the sector's growing importance within the agriculture and allied sector and has highlighted the role of livestock in stabilizing rural livelihoods. Livestock acts as a safety net for small and marginal farmers and generates alternative employment opportunities and strengthens India's position in global markets. The increasing export footprint of India's livestock sector underlines the need for harmonized quality standards, disease-free zones, and product diversification to fully capitalize on emerging global opportunities. Moving forward, it is important to generate investment avenues in technology, genetics and climate-resilient practises to ensure fodder availability, disease control, and continued production and productivity so that this momentum is sustained and further strengthened.